

Q I'm planning to breast-feed. Is it a good idea to buy a nursing pillow?

A nursing pillow is usually a V-shaped or U-shaped cushion that supports your baby while she breast-feeds so you don't have to hold her continually, or you can use it to support your arms as you feed her so you don't get too tired or cramped.

Some women find these nursing pillows extremely useful, especially in the early weeks of breast-feeding when you and your baby are working on your technique and finding the most comfortable positions. The cushion sits around your waist and supports either your baby while she nurses, or your arms, depending on whether you want to cradle her as she nurses. Having this cushioned support under your baby or your arms stops you from craning forward during a nursing session, so your posture is improved and your milk flow isn't hampered. However, you can try using ordinary cushions to

create a similar support if you feel a nursing pillow isn't worth it. If you do invest in a nursing pillow, it can double as a baby nest once your baby is a little older, acting as a support for her to lean against before she is able to sit up unaided.



Baby bolster Cushions have a wide section on which to lay your baby.

NURSING PILLOW



Using a nursing pillow Sit comfortably with your back supported. Wrap the cushion around your waist and position your baby at the right angle to nurse.

Q It's getting harder to get a decent night's sleep as I grow bigger. Is there anything that can help?

Strategically placed pillows can help to bolster your belly and support your legs and back. As your abdomen grows, it can be hard to find a comfortable sleeping position. After around 16 weeks of pregnancy, lying on your back puts a strain on it and becomes more difficult. You should avoid this position anyway because it puts pressure on the major blood vessels—the aorta and the major vein called the inferior vena cava—and affects the blood circulation to you and your baby, making you feel faint. Don't worry, however, if during the night you turn onto your back—if your body feels unwell it will turn naturally to a more suitable position while you are asleep. Lying on your side, specifically your left side, is thought to optimize your circulation, and is usually the most comfortable position later in pregnancy. However, your

abdomen can feel unsupported when you lie on your side, so many women find they need some support aids to be comfortable in this position (see pp.114–5).

Support pillows

You can try using one of the many pregnancy pillows available: there is a whole range of designs to choose from, and some are multipurpose, providing support during the daytime, too, and doubling as nursing pillows once your baby arrives. Compact wedge-shaped cushions slip under your belly when you lie on your side, and can also be used as a lower back support while sitting. For ultimate support, you can invest in a body-length pillow; these long pillows curl around your body supporting your belly, back, and legs while you sleep. After the birth, you can use them for supporting your baby's weight during nursing sessions. If you don't want to spend money on pregnancy pillows, you can use strategically placed bed pillows and cushions to create the extra support that you need.

Body-length pillows cradle your whole body while you sleep and are one of the most **popular** pregnancy accessories.

Q Which inflatable cushions are most helpful for sitting down if I've had stitches after the delivery?

If you need stitches after a tear or episiotomy (see p.217) during the birth, an inflatable cushion can help to take the pressure off your perineal area when you sit down and bring temporary relief. You are likely to feel sore and tender in the perineal area as your incision heals, which can make sitting down uncomfortable. There are a few types to choose from:

» **C-shaped inflatable cushion** helps you avoid putting pressure on one particular area.

» **Valley-style cushion** is a uniquely designed cushion using a combination of foam and air, with two inflatable sides that you can adjust accordingly and a dip in the middle. You may be able to rent one of these cushions rather than buy it.

» **Doughnut-shaped inflatable cushions** with a hole in the center are also available. These cushions will enable you to avoid putting any pressure on your perineum when you sit down, although you should avoid sitting on these types of cushion for too long, since they can compress the area, which could become uncomfortable in itself.